



Ancient Greece

Often called the “cradle of Western civilization,” ancient Greece was one of the first well-developed civilizations in Europe. At its peak, around 2,500 years ago, it stretched across vast areas of the ancient world. The ancient Greeks made important contributions to philosophy, politics, mathematics, science, and the arts. Their influence shaped the Western world.

In ancient times, Greece was not a single unified country, but a collection of more than 1,000 city-states, such as Athens, Sparta, Thebes, and Syracuse. Each city-state was known as a *polis*, and governed itself independently.

These city-states were often at war with each other, with each struggling to be the strongest power in the region. But in the 4th century BCE they were all conquered and brought under the rule of Philip II of Macedonia.

After Philip’s death, his son Alexander set about extending Greek territory and influence, building an empire that stretched into North Africa and Central Asia.

Greek power over the ancient world continued until the mighty Roman Empire (see pp.46–47) came to dominance in 146BCE, although that did not end the influence of Greek culture around the Mediterranean and the Western world.

▲ CITY-STATES

Each Greek city-state had its own laws, customs, and currency. Up to the 5th century, Athens was the most powerful city-state. Its most powerful fortress was the Acropolis, built on a hill above the city. At its center was the Parthenon temple, which still stands today.



▲ ATHENIAN DEMOCRACY

Athens developed one of the earliest democracies, giving citizens the right to vote, though women and enslaved people were excluded. A device called a kleroterion (above) was used to choose citizens at random to fill government roles.